



FUNDRAISING



Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: EIGHT SLEEP / EIGHT SLEEP

Roughly [one in three adults in the U.S. regularly gets insufficient sleep](#), driving demand for tools that can monitor, analyze, and enhance rest. [Eight Sleep](#), founded in 2014, offers AI-powered sleep tech products that promise to transform your bed into a preventive health device.

The New York-based startup announced Tuesday that it raised a fresh \$100 million round from investors such as HSG, Valor Equity Partners, Founders Fund, Y Combinator and athletes including Ferrari F1 driver Charles Leclerc, and Zak Brown, who is the CEO of McLaren F1.

With this round, Eight Sleep has raised roughly \$260 million total, Pitchbook estimates. It previously raised an \$86 million Series C in 2021 by investors who assigned it a [\\$500 million post-money valuation](#). Eight Sleep said its valuation has doubled since its last round, but didn't disclose specifics.

"If we successfully execute our AI roadmap, launch internationally, and develop condition-specific interventions, achieving unicorn status will naturally follow," Alexandra Zatarain, co-founder and CMO of Eight Sleep, told TechCrunch.

Eight offers smart mattresses that integrate software and AI to track and enhance sleep quality. Its flagship product, Pod, offers features like measuring sleep stages, heart rate, breathing patterns, and movement. Using these insights, it automatically adjusts temperature, elevation, and firmness. It can also detect snoring and automatically elevate the base in response, according to the company.

The company has generated more than \$500 million in Pod sales, expanded its revenue tenfold since launching the product in 2019, and collected insights from over one billion hours of recorded sleep data, it says.

Eight, which employs just over 100 full-time staff, is now expanding beyond the Pod with its Sleep Agent, an AI-driven system that leverages large language models to create thousands of digital twins for each user and predict outcomes, with the goal of optimizing nightly recovery. This approach shifts sleep technology from reactive tracking to proactive, personalized intervention, said Zatarain.



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The sleep tech market features a range of competitors, from wearable devices such as Oura, Fitbit, and Apple, to medical-focused companies like ResMed, as well as smart mattress and sleep surface makers, including Sleep Number and ChiliSleep.

Eight's core differentiator, Autopilot, "builds a personal blueprint from night one, then adapts continuously, accounting for seasonality, travel, stress, training, illness, or even a bad night before. And it works independently for each side of the bed," Zatarain said.

The startup plans to use the new funding to accelerate its growth in the medical sector, building on the Pod's health-monitoring capabilities. With the introduction of Health Check, the system can monitor cardiovascular and respiratory patterns with up to 99% accuracy without the need for wearable devices, according to the company.

"We're not replacing your doctor, but we are giving you nightly, high-accuracy health monitoring so you can act early if trends shift. Over time, this data can complement medical care," Zatarain said.

Eight's recently launched [Hot Flash Mode](#) employs AI-driven cooling to relieve menopause symptoms. It is also working on contactless solutions for sleep apnea. The company is pursuing FDA approval and will utilize the Pod's real-time biometric monitoring to deliver personalized interventions.

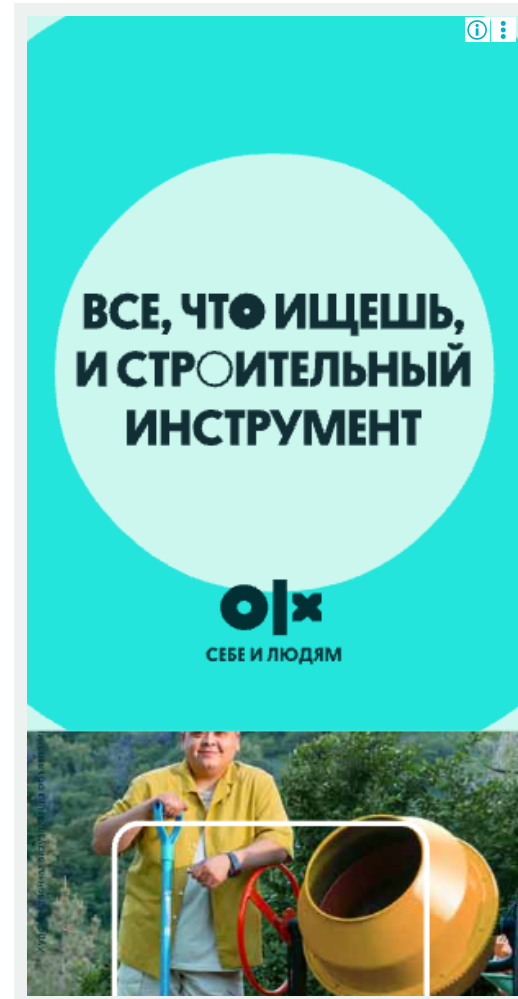
Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world's largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale's regulations, including for data storage.

"Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and unlike many devices, we don't use microphones. Our biometric sensors are embedded in the bed surface — no wearables, no invasiveness, just passive, high-accuracy insights," Zatarain said.

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Kate Park is a reporter at TechCrunch, with a focus on technology, startups and venture capital in Asia. She previously was a financial journalist at Mergermarket...

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IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

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Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT • August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”



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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn’t the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn’t really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn’t think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won’t necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I’m seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That’s the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

AI



Texas attorney general accuses Meta, Character.AI of misleading kids with mental health claims

Rebecca Bellan — 10:59 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Texas attorney general Ken Paxton has launched an investigation into both Meta AI Studio and Character.AI for “potentially engaging in deceptive trade practices and misleadingly marketing themselves as mental health tools,” according to a [press release](#) issued Monday.

“In today’s digital age, we must continue to fight to protect Texas kids from deceptive and exploitative technology,” Paxton is quoted as saying. “By posing as sources of emotional support, AI platforms can mislead vulnerable users, especially children, into believing they’re receiving legitimate mental health care. In reality, they’re often being fed recycled, generic responses engineered to align with harvested personal data and disguised as therapeutic advice.”

The probe comes a few days after [Senator Josh Hawley announced an investigation into Meta](#) following a report that found its AI chatbots were interacting inappropriately with children, including by flirting.

The Texas Attorney General’s office has accused Meta and [Character.AI](#) of creating AI personas that present as “professional therapeutic tools, despite lacking proper medical credentials or oversight.”

Among the millions of AI personas available on Character.AI, one user-created bot called [Psychologist](#) has seen high demand among the startup’s young users. Meanwhile, Meta doesn’t offer therapy bots for kids, but there’s nothing stopping children from using the Meta AI chatbot or one of the personas created by third parties for therapeutic purposes.

“We clearly label AIs, and to help people better understand their limitations, we include a disclaimer that responses are generated by AI — not people,” Meta spokesperson Ryan Daniels told TechCrunch. “These AIs aren’t licensed professionals and our models are designed to direct users to seek qualified medical or safety professionals when appropriate.”

However, TechCrunch noted that many children may not understand — or may simply ignore — such disclaimers. We have asked Meta what additional safeguards it takes to protect minors using its chatbots.

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For its part, Character includes prominent disclaimers in every chat to remind users that a “Character” is not a real person, and everything they say should be treated as fiction, according to a Character.AI spokesperson. She noted that the startup adds additional disclaimers when users create Characters with the words “psychologist,” “therapist,” or “doctor” to not rely on them for any type of professional advice.

In his statement, Paxton also observed that though AI chatbots assert confidentiality, their “terms of service reveal that user interactions are logged, tracked, and exploited for targeted advertising and algorithmic



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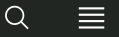
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development, raising serious concerns about privacy violations, data abuse, and false advertising.”

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information is used to train AI, tailor the service to personal preferences, and provide targeted advertising, including sharing data with advertisers and analytics providers.

A Character.AI spokesperson said the startup is “just beginning to explore targeted advertising on the platform” and that those explorations “have not involved using the content of chats on the platform.”

The spokesperson also confirmed that the same privacy policy applies to all users, even teenagers.

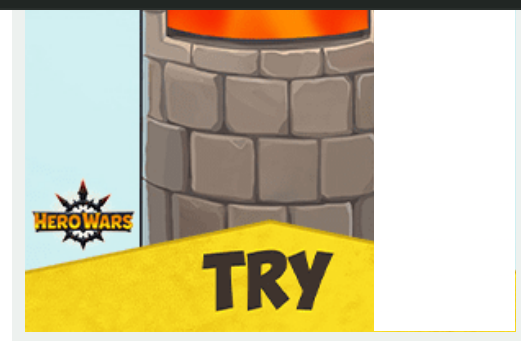
TechCrunch has asked Meta such tracking is done on children, too, and will update this story if we hear back.

Both Meta and Character say their services aren’t designed for children under 13. That said, Meta has come under fire for failing to police accounts created by kids under 13, and Character’s kid-friendly characters are clearly designed to attract younger users. The startup’s CEO, Karandeep Anand, has even said that his [six-year-old daughter](#) uses the platform’s chatbots under his supervision.

That type of data collection, targeted advertising, and algorithmic exploitation is exactly what legislation like KOSA (Kids Online Safety Act) is meant to protect against. KOSA was teed up to pass last year with strong bipartisan support, but it stalled after major pushback from tech industry lobbyists. Meta in particular deployed a formidable lobbying machine, warning lawmakers that the bill’s broad mandates would undercut its business model.

[KOSA was reintroduced](#) to the Senate in May 2025 by Senators Marsha Blackburn (R-TN) and Richard Blumenthal (D-CT).

Paxton has issued civil investigative demands — legal orders that require a company to produce documents, data, or testimony during a government probe — to the companies to determine if they have violated Texas consumer protection laws.



This story was updated with comments from a Character.AI spokesperson.

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Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch where she covers the business, policy, and emerging trends shaping artificial intelligence. Her work has also...

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iPhone 17, the ‘thinnest iPhone ever,’ and everything else we’re expecting out of Apple’s hardware event



Apple usually announces its new hardware in the fall, and this year is likely no different. The event is reported to be on September 9, and Apple is expected to release its iPhone 17 lineup, along with updates for the Apple Watch and AirPods.

As always, there are many rumors circulating, including bigger screens and improved cameras for the iPhone 17 models and the introduction of an ultra-thin iPhone Air that could replace the Plus model.

iPhone 17, 17 Pro, and 17 Pro Max

The iPhone 17 is expected to get a significant makeover to align more closely with the Pro models. It could feature a slightly larger [6.3-inch screen](#), which is an increase of 0.2 inches compared to the iPhone 16, as well as a [120Hz display](#), a substantial upgrade from the current 60Hz. It's also rumored to have a 24-megapixel front camera. It could also come in new colors: purple and green.

IMAGE CREDITS: CHENG XIN / GETTY IMAGES

iPhone 17: Purple and Green Colors in Testing as Potential New Shade for 2025

Full Article: <https://t.co/jZJJoUHBsf pic.twitter.com/1in8R6dDa5>

— Majin Bu (@MajinBuOfficial) [June 20, 2025](#)

The Pro's upgrades will be noticeable on the back of the phone, rumors suggest. [Conceptual renderings](#) show that the three rear cameras may be arranged in a rectangular bar that extends from one edge of the device to the other. The flash, light sensor, and microphone would be positioned far to the right side. Where the MagSafe charger is, the Apple logo is said to be centered for aesthetic reasons.

Notably, the iPhone 17 Pro may switch materials, potentially replacing the titanium band around the screen with aluminum. This could help Apple reduce costs as well as provide a lighter feel.

The iPhone 17 Pro Max is expected to see fewer upgrades, too, with the most significant change being a slightly thicker body, likely to accommodate a larger battery — which would be a huge win.

According to [leaker Instant Digital](#), the iPhone 17 is predicted to be priced around \$800, and the Pro Max is expected to have a price tag of \$1,250. New colors for the Pro models potentially include [dark blue and copper](#).

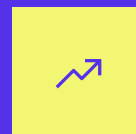
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The Pro model is expected to be priced around \$1,050. However, a [recent leak](#) indicates that there will be fewer storage options compared to the 16 Pro. Users may lose the 128GB option and will only have three choices: 256GB, 512GB, or 1TB, down from the typical four options.

iPhone Air

IMAGE CREDITS:APPLE TRACK

The most widely discussed rumor is that Apple might be introducing its slimmest phone ever, [the iPhone Air](#), which may replace the iPhone Plus.

This rumored device is said to have a profile thickness of 5.5 mm, making it about 0.08 inches thinner than current iPhones. It'll also feature a 6.6-inch screen.

This move appears to be Apple's response to the trend of slimmer smartphones, following in the footsteps of other companies like Samsung and Huawei. The iPhone Air could potentially outshine the Samsung Galaxy S25 Edge, which measures 5.8 mm thick. Additionally, it may pave the way for [Apple's long-rumored foldable phone](#), predicted to launch in September 2026.

While the thin design is stylish, it would come with some compromises. Based on the [renders](#) we've seen, the Air is expected to have only one

rear camera lens, unlike the Plus, which has two. There are also [rumors](#) that there may not be enough space for a speaker at the bottom, meaning the only audio source could be the front earpiece at the top.

Reports suggest the device will be priced at \$950 and will be available in black, silver, and light gold.

Apple Watch Series 11, Ultra 3, and SE 3

IMAGE CREDITS:APPLE

After a two-year wait, there are various rumors surrounding the Apple Watch Ultra 3, suggesting it will undergo significant changes. These may include faster charging speeds, 5G support, and satellite connectivity. Additionally, it's speculated that the watch will feature a [larger display](#).

One of the most exciting potential upgrades for both the Ultra 3 and Series 11 is the incorporation of blood pressure monitoring capabilities. This feature would notify users if their blood pressure levels are too high or too low. Apple is also considering adding a sleep apnea feature. However, according to Bloomberg's Mark Gurman, the company [may need to delay the release of these features for further tweaks](#).

Apple recently announced that a [redesigned blood oxygen feature](#) is rolling out to some Series 8, 10, and Ultra watches. This leads us to think the Ultra 3 may also get the capability, but the company didn't mention if it would be available in the watchOS 26 in its announcement.

The third generation of Apple Watch SE isn't expected to receive major updates, aside from possibly a larger display. There continue to be reports of a plastic version being introduced, according to Gurman.

Rumored prices for the watches are: \$250 for the Apple Watch SE 3, \$400 for the Series 11, and \$800 for the Ultra 3.

AirPods Pro 3

IMAGE CREDITS:APPLE

After the release of the AirPods Pro 2 in 2022, it's about time for an upgrade, and Apple might just be ready to deliver. [Rumors](#) suggest that the AirPods Pro 3 will feature a sleeker design, touch-sensitive controls, smaller earbuds, and a slimmer case. Additionally, the H3 chip is expected to enhance active noise cancellation and adaptive audio.

This story has been updated to include additional rumors.

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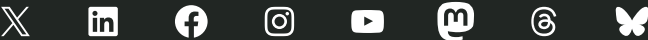


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